

MUSTARD SEED

Action Plan & Implementation Roadmap

A step-by-step guide for building the business from scratch

Solo Founder | Bootstrap | Pilot-First

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Companion document to the Mustard Seed Business Plan V2.0

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1. Pre-Launch Checklist

Complete these before committing any money or approaching clients. Estimated time: 2–4 weeks.

1.1 Legal & Administrative

- ☐ Register company with Companies House (Ltd) — ~£50 online
- ☐ Open a business bank account (Starling, Tide, or Monzo Business — free)
- ☐ Register for HMRC Self Assessment or Corporation Tax
- ☐ Get professional indemnity insurance — ~£200–400/year for consulting
- ☐ Draft standard equity agreement template — use Seedlegals (~£500) or DIY with legal templates
- ☐ Register ICO data protection (if handling client data) — £40/year

Estimated cost: £500–£1,000

Timeline: Week 1–2

1.2 Brand & Digital Presence

- ☐ Secure domain name (mustardseed.co.uk or similar) — ~£10/year
- ☐ Create a simple landing page — use Carrd.co (£19/year) or free WordPress
- ☐ Set up professional email (Google Workspace — £5/month)
- ☐ Create LinkedIn company page
- ☐ Design basic logo — Canva (free) or Fiverr (£20–50)
- ☐ Write a one-page service overview PDF

Estimated cost: £50–£150

Timeline: Week 2–3

1.3 Service Preparation

- ☐ Build the diagnostic framework (business health assessment template)
- ☐ Create a standard onboarding pack for new portfolio companies
- ☐ Design pricing sheets for training and financial advisory services
- ☐ Prepare a portfolio company selection scorecard (criteria for choosing clients)
- ☐ Write template equity agreement with staged milestone clauses
- ☐ Create a simple CRM tracker (Excel or free HubSpot)

Estimated cost: £0 (your time only)

Timeline: Week 2–4

1.4 Network & Pipeline

- ☐ Identify 15–20 target businesses (through churches, business networks, LinkedIn)

- ☐ Join 2–3 faith-based business networks (CREO, Navigators NEC, local church business groups)
- ☐ Attend 2–3 startup/SME events in your area
- ☐ Reach out to 5 businesses for informal conversations (not selling — learning)
- ☐ Build a simple referral pipeline tracker

Estimated cost: £0–£100 (event tickets)

Timeline: Week 3–4

2. Phase 1: Foundation (Months 1–3)

Goal: Generate first revenue from consulting and training while signing first portfolio company.

2.1 Revenue Actions

Priority: Generate cash flow immediately through fee-based services.

- Offer business health diagnostics as a paid service (£300–£500 per diagnostic)
- Run first training workshop — target 5–10 attendees at £150–£300 each
- Take on 1–2 hourly consulting clients (£75–£150/hr) for immediate income
- Offer financial advisory to 1–2 clients (£300–£500 per engagement)

Month 1 target: £1,000–£2,000 from consulting/training

Month 2 target: £2,000–£3,000 (repeat clients + new leads)

Month 3 target: £3,000–£4,000 (training + consulting + first equity signing)

2.2 Portfolio Development

- Shortlist 5 businesses from your pipeline using the selection scorecard
- Run diagnostic assessments with top 3 candidates
- Present partnership proposals to 2 strongest candidates
- Sign first portfolio company — 3-month pilot, 3–5% equity stake
- Begin embedded work (2–3 days/week with first portfolio company)

2.3 Marketing & Outreach

- Post weekly on LinkedIn about small business growth (establish authority)
- Share diagnostic insights (anonymised) as thought leadership
- Ask first consulting clients for testimonials
- Attend 1 networking event per month

2.4 Time Allocation (Solo Founder)

Activity	Days/Week	Hours/Week	Notes
Portfolio company (embedded)	2–3	16–24	Once first company signed (Month 2+)
Consulting clients	1–2	8–16	Pays the bills immediately
Training/workshops	0.5	4	Monthly workshops + prep
Admin/marketing/pipeline	0.5–1	4–8	LinkedIn, networking, CRM
TOTAL	5	~40	Sustainable founder workload

2.5 End-of-Phase Checkpoint

Before moving to Phase 2, answer these honestly:

- ☐ Have I generated at least £5,000 in fee revenue in 3 months?

- ☐ Is my first portfolio company signed and progressing?
- ☐ Do I have a pipeline of 3+ interested businesses?
- ☐ Am I working sustainable hours (not burning out)?

If 3/4 are YES → move to Phase 2. If not → extend Phase 1 by 1–2 months.

3. Phase 2: First Clients (Months 4–6)

Goal: Establish 2–3 portfolio companies, build case studies, and reach £10K quarterly revenue.

3.1 Portfolio Expansion

- Sign second portfolio company (3-month pilot, 3–5% equity)
- First portfolio company: review KPIs and decide on Stage 2 equity (3–5% additional)
- Begin conversations with 3rd candidate
- Document everything — processes, frameworks, results (this becomes your IP)

3.2 Revenue Growth

- Increase training workshops to twice monthly
- Raise consulting rates by 10–15% if demand supports it
- Introduce group training sessions (higher revenue per hour)
- Target: £10,000–£12,000 quarterly revenue from fees alone

3.3 Faith Network Development

- Partner with 1–2 churches for business ministry events
- Join or establish a local faith-and-business meetup
- Connect with CREO Ventures or Navigators NEC for referrals
- Position Mustard Seed as the 'go-to' for faith-driven entrepreneurs

3.4 Systems & Processes

- Create a standard 90-day diagnostic playbook (repeatable for each new company)
- Build a KPI tracking dashboard for portfolio companies
- Automate invoicing and time tracking
- Write case study from first portfolio company (with permission)

3.5 End-of-Phase Checkpoint

- ☐ Am I generating £10K+ per quarter from fees?
- ☐ Do I have 2+ active portfolio companies?
- ☐ Has my first portfolio company hit at least 1 milestone?
- ☐ Is demand exceeding my solo capacity? (this triggers Phase 3 hiring)

If 3/4 are YES → move to Phase 3. If demand isn't exceeding capacity, extend Phase 2.

4. Phase 3: Prove the Model (Months 7–12)

Goal: Reach £40K annual revenue, prove the embedded model works, prepare for scaling.

4.1 Growth & Hiring Decision

Hire **ONLY** if **ALL** three conditions are met:

- You have 4+ portfolio companies (or demand for them)
- Fee revenue covers your costs + the new hire's salary for 3 months
- You are consistently working >50 hours/week and turning away work

If conditions aren't met, continue solo. There is no shame in a profitable solo practice.

4.2 If Hiring: First Consultant

- Part-time or contract initially (£25–£35K pro-rata, or £150–£250/day contractor)
- Focus: someone who complements your weaknesses (finance person if you're ops-focused, or vice versa)
- Trial period: 3 months, paid from fee revenue (not savings)
- They manage 2 portfolio companies while you manage 2 + business development

4.3 Portfolio Milestones

- First portfolio company: complete Stage 2, begin Stage 3 (independence milestones)
- Total portfolio: 3–4 companies with measurable growth metrics
- Publish 2+ case studies
- First equity return: even a small dividend or valuation increase validates the model

4.4 Revenue Targets

Revenue Stream	Monthly Target	Annual (Y1)	% of Revenue
Consulting fees	£1,500	£18,000	45%
Training workshops	£800	£9,600	24%
Financial advisory	£500	£6,000	15%
Diagnostic services	£500	£6,000	15%
TOTAL	£3,300	~£40,000	100%

Note: Equity value (£30K estimated at year-end) is NOT counted as revenue — it's long-term upside.

4.5 End-of-Year Checkpoint

- ☐ Did I hit £35K+ in fee revenue?
- ☐ Do I have 3+ portfolio companies with documented progress?
- ☐ Is at least one portfolio company ready for independence (Stage 3)?
- ☐ Do I have a repeatable playbook that someone else could follow?

If YES to most → proceed to Year 2 scaling. If not → consolidate and extend.

5. Phase 4: Scale (Year 2+)

Goal: Grow to 6–8 portfolio companies, £90K revenue, and establish Mustard Seed as a brand.

5.1 Team Growth (Trigger-Based)

Trigger	Action	Cost	Funded By
4+ companies, >50hr weeks	Hire consultant #1 (part-time)	£25–30K	Fee revenue
6+ companies	Hire financial specialist (part-time)	£28–32K	Fee revenue
Revenue >£150K	Consider small seed round (£50–100K)	Dilution	Angel/faith investors
8+ companies	Consider full-time ops hire	£30–35K	Fee + equity returns

Golden rule: Every hire must be funded by existing revenue, not by projections.

5.2 Revenue Expansion

- Introduce tiered training programmes (basic → advanced → masterclass)
- Launch online/digital training (recurring revenue, lower delivery cost)
- Consider a small fund structure for external investors (Year 3+)
- Cross-referral between portfolio companies (network effect)

5.3 Brand & Reputation

- Speak at 2–3 events per year (church business events, startup conferences)
- Publish annual 'Impact Report' showing portfolio company growth
- Build relationships with angel investors and faith-driven funds
- Media coverage: Christian business publications, local press, startup media

6. Decision Gates & Kill Criteria

Every phase has a 'continue or pivot' checkpoint. These gates are non-negotiable.

Gate	Timing	Continue If...	Pivot/Pause If...	Kill If...
Gate 1	Month 3	£5K+ revenue, 1 company signed	Revenue <£3K, no companies	Zero revenue, zero pipeline
Gate 2	Month 6	£10K+ quarterly, 2+ companies	Revenue flat, no growth	Losing money, clients leaving
Gate 3	Month 12	£35K+ annual, 3+ companies	Revenue <£25K	Can't cover basic costs
Gate 4	Month 18	£60K+ annual, clear demand	Growth stalled	Model not working at scale

6.1 What 'Pivot' Means

- If portfolio model isn't working: Become a pure consulting firm (still profitable)
- If equity isn't attractive to clients: Switch to revenue-share model
- If faith-niche is too small: Expand to general small business market
- If solo model is maxed: Partner with another consultant (equity partnership)

Mustard Seed is designed so that the worst-case outcome is a profitable consulting business. There is no scenario where you lose everything if you follow the gates.

7. Budget & Spending Timeline

Total startup cost: ~£1,000–£1,500. All funded from savings or first month's revenue.

7.1 Pre-Launch Spending (Before Month 1)

Item	Cost	When	Essential?
Company registration	£50	Week 1	Yes
Professional indemnity insurance	£200–400	Week 1	Yes
Equity agreement template (Seedlegals)	£500	Week 2	Yes
Domain + email	£80/year	Week 2	Yes
Logo (Canva/Fiverr)	£0–50	Week 3	Nice to have
Landing page (Carrrd)	£19/year	Week 3	Nice to have
ICO registration	£40/year	Week 4	If handling data
TOTAL	£890–£1,140		

7.2 Monthly Running Costs (Solo Phase)

Item	Monthly Cost	Annual	Notes
Google Workspace	£5	£60	Professional email
Insurance	£20–35	£240–420	Professional indemnity
Software (CRM, tools)	£0–30	£0–360	Free tier where possible
Travel/networking	£50–100	£600–1,200	Events, client visits
Marketing/content	£0–50	£0–600	Mostly organic/free
TOTAL	£75–£220	£900–£2,640	

At £75–£220/month running costs, you need just 1–2 consulting hours per month to stay alive. The business is nearly impossible to kill if you keep costs this low.

8. Risk Register & Contingencies

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Can't find portfolio companies	Medium	High	Continue consulting-only — still profitable
Portfolio company fails	Medium	Medium	Staged equity limits loss; diversify across 3+ companies
Client disputes equity terms	Low	High	Use Seedlegals template; mutual exit rights at every stage
Burnout (solo founder)	High	High	Strict 40hr/week; hire trigger-based; take holidays
Market downturn	Medium	Medium	SMEs still need help in downturns; consulting demand may increase
Competitor enters niche	Low	Low	First-mover advantage; faith network loyalty; embedded model hard to copy
Regulatory changes (FCA)	Low	Medium	Monitor; financial advisory may need FCA permissions depending on scope
Cash flow gaps	Medium	High	Keep 3 months expenses in reserve (£600–£1,000); invoice promptly

9. Key Milestones Calendar

Month	Milestone	Success Metric	Revenue Target
Pre-launch	Legal setup complete	Company registered, insurance live	—
Month 1	First paid client	£1K+ revenue	£1,000
Month 2	First portfolio company signed	Equity agreement executed	£2,000
Month 3	Gate 1 checkpoint	£5K+ cumulative revenue	£3,000
Month 4	First training workshop	5+ attendees, positive feedback	£3,000
Month 5	Second portfolio company	Signed + diagnostic complete	£3,500
Month 6	Gate 2 checkpoint	£10K+ quarterly, 2 companies	£4,000
Month 9	First case study published	Documented client success	£4,500
Month 12	Gate 3 checkpoint	£35K+ annual, 3+ companies	£5,000
Month 15	First hire (if triggered)	Demand exceeds solo capacity	£6,000
Month 18	Gate 4 checkpoint	£60K+ annual, scaling model	£7,000
Month 24	Year 2 target	£90K revenue, 6-8 companies	£8,000

10. Weekly Rhythm & Time Allocation

A suggested weekly structure for a solo founder. Adjust based on portfolio company needs.

Day	AM (9am–1pm)	PM (1pm–5pm)	Notes
Monday	Portfolio Company A	Portfolio Company A	Full day embedded
Tuesday	Portfolio Company A	Consulting clients	Split day
Wednesday	Portfolio Company B	Portfolio Company B	Full day embedded (from Month 2)
Thursday	Consulting clients	Training prep / delivery	Revenue-generating
Friday	Admin / marketing / CRM	Networking / pipeline	Business development
Weekend	OFF	OFF	Protect this — burnout kills businesses

Total: ~40 hours/week. If you consistently exceed 50 hours for 4+ weeks, that's a hiring trigger, not a sign of dedication.

Final Notes

This action plan is designed for one person with limited capital to build a real business. Every decision — from hiring to expansion — is triggered by demand, not by ambition.

The beauty of the Mustard Seed model is that it cannot fail catastrophically. At worst, you run a profitable consulting practice. At best, you build a portfolio of growing businesses that generate equity returns for decades.

Start small. Prove the model. Scale what works. Stop what doesn't.

"From the smallest seed grows the largest tree."

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